Certificate Designer

User Guidance

The CPD Group | Platform Documentation

Registered Address
The Manor House
High Street, Rothwell
Northamptonshire
NN14 6BQ

Contact Details
0300 3732 528
www.thecpd.group
info@thecpd.group
Company No: 10912224

Overview

The Certificate Designer gives you full control over how your CPD certificates look. You can create a branded, professional certificate template that reflects your organisation's identity — choosing everything from border styles and colour schemes to logos, signatures, and layout.

This guide walks through every option available to you, explains what each setting does, and clarifies which elements are fixed and cannot be removed. These fixed elements exist to protect the integrity and verifiability of every certificate issued.

> **Before you start** Changes you make in the Certificate Designer apply to the template for that activity. You can also save designs as presets and roll them out across multiple accreditations. A live preview updates as you work, so you can see exactly how your certificate will look before saving.

What You Can and Cannot Change — At a Glance

You can customise...	
Border pattern & page style	Sets the overall look and frame of the certificate
Background, title & line colours	Adjust the colour palette to match your brand
Organisation logos (up to 3)	Upload, position and size each logo independently
Custom background image	Replace the generated pattern with your own full-page artwork
QR code position	Move the verification QR code to suit your layout
Date position	Reposition the date field anywhere on the certificate
CPD credits display	Configure how credits appear on the badge
Main heading	Choose from standard options or enter a custom heading

You can customise...	
Signatures (up to 3)	Add signatory names with optional role labels
Preview name	Test how delegate names render before going live

Fixed elements (cannot be removed)	Why
Date field	Essential for identifying when the learner participated in their CPD
Verification QR code	Forms an integral part of the certificate verification process
Course title	Required to identify what CPD was completed
Signature field	Required to authenticate the certificate
Accredited Activity Logo	Confirms the activity's accreditation status
Learner name	Identifies who the certificate was issued to

Design Options — Detailed Guide

1. Border Pattern and Page Style

The border pattern and page style set the foundational visual framework of your certificate. Choose from a range of pre-designed combinations to establish the overall look — from clean and minimal to more decorative styles.

- Select a border pattern from the available options in the panel.
- Select a page style to set the layout structure.
- These two choices work together — experiment with combinations until you find what suits your brand.

> **Tip** If you plan to upload your own full-page background image (see section 5), the border pattern will be replaced by your image — so you don't need to spend time on this setting if you're going the custom route.

2. Background, Title and Line Colours

Three colour settings let you dial in your brand palette:

Colour Setting	What It Controls
Background colour	The fill colour behind the certificate content and pattern
Title colour	Applied to the main heading and key text elements
Line colour	Applied to decorative lines, dividers, and the date section line

Use your brand's hex colour codes for precision, or use the colour picker to select visually.

3. Organisation Logos

You can upload up to three organisation logos and position each one independently on the certificate. This is useful if your certificate needs to display your own logo alongside a partner or funding organisation's mark.

- Supported formats: PNG or JPG. PNG with a transparent background is recommended for a clean result.
- Aspect ratio is always preserved — your logos will never appear stretched or squashed.
- Each logo has its own position and size controls, adjusted independently.
- Use the preview to check logos aren't overlapping other certificate elements.

> **Tip** If your logo has a white background, consider using a PNG with transparency so it sits cleanly over any background colour or pattern you've chosen.

4. Custom Full-Page Background

Instead of using the system-generated pattern and border, you can upload your own full-page artwork to use as the certificate background. This gives you complete creative freedom over the certificate's visual style.

How it works:

- Your uploaded image replaces the border pattern and background colour entirely.
- All other elements — the learner name, course title, dates, credits, accreditation number, logos, signatures, and the verification QR code — continue to render on top of your image, unchanged.
- The image is stretched to fill the full certificate area.

> **Recommended image specification** Use a PNG or JPG at 3583 × 2557 pixels in landscape orientation (approximately 1.4:1 ratio). This matches the certificate canvas exactly and will produce the sharpest possible result. Images that don't match this ratio will be stretched to fit.

Things to consider when designing your background image:

- Leave clear space in the areas where the learner name, course title, signatures, logos, QR code, and date will appear — these are rendered on top and should remain legible.

- Avoid very dark or very busy areas in those zones, as text and logos need to remain visible.
- Use the preview to check how certificate content sits over your artwork before saving.

5. Verification QR Code Position

Every certificate includes a verification QR code displayed inside a "Scan to Verify" border. This QR code links to a unique verification page tied to the specific activity, allowing anyone to confirm a certificate's authenticity.

You cannot remove the QR code, but you can choose where it sits on the certificate. Use the position controls to move it to a location that works with your design — typically a corner or edge area where it won't obscure the certificate's main content.

> **Note** The URL linked by the QR code is set automatically based on the activity. You control only the position of the code on the certificate, not the destination URL.

6. Date Position

The date field shows when the learner participated in their CPD activity. It is a required element on every certificate and cannot be removed, but you can reposition it to suit your layout.

The date section moves as a single unit — the date text, the line beneath it, and the "DATE" caption all move together when you adjust the position. This keeps the date area visually consistent regardless of where it's placed on the page.

7. CPD Credits Display

If your activity carries CPD credits, you can configure how those credits are displayed on the certificate badge. Options typically include the number of credits or CPD Minutes. Adjust these settings to match your activity's credit structure and how you want them presented to delegates.

8. Main Heading

The main heading appears at the top of the certificate and is one of the most prominent text elements. You have two options:

- Choose from a set of standard heading options (e.g. "Certificate of Completion", "Certificate of Attendance").
- Enter a custom heading — type any text you'd like to appear as the main heading.

The heading colour is controlled by the Title colour setting covered in section 2.

9. Activity Title

The activity title on the certificate is pulled live from your activity record — it always reflects the current name of the activity as it exists in the system. This means you don't need to update your certificate template if you rename an activity; the certificate will automatically reflect the updated name.

The title wraps automatically to up to three rows on the certificate, so longer activity names are accommodated without truncation. Keep in mind that very long titles may use all three rows — where possible, keep activity names concise for the best visual result.

10. Signatures

You can add up to three signatures to your certificate — for example, a course director, a CEO, or an external signatory.

- Type the name of the signatory and select the font of the signature.
- Each signature can have an optional role label displayed below the signature line (e.g. "Chief Executive", "Head of Learning").
- If you leave the role field empty, nothing appears below the signature line — the line itself still shows.
- Position each signature independently on the certificate.

11. Preview Name

Before saving your design, you can enter a delegate name in the Preview Name field to see exactly how it will appear on a real certificate. This is useful for checking:

- That long names don't overflow or overlap other elements.
- That the font size and position work well for typical name lengths.
- That the overall certificate looks right with real content in place.

The preview name is for display purposes only — it does not affect any issued certificate.

Saving and Applying Your Design

Save Design

Once you're happy with your certificate template, save it to apply it to that activity. The saved design will be used for all certificates issued for that accreditation going forward.

Roll Out to Other Accreditations

If you have multiple accreditations and want a consistent look across them, you can roll out a saved design to other activities in one step — rather than rebuilding the design from scratch for each one.

> **Note** Rolling out a design will apply your current template to the selected activities. Review each activity's certificate after doing this to confirm the result looks right, particularly if activities have different title lengths or credit structures.

Download a High-Resolution Preview

You can download a high-resolution preview of your certificate at any point. This is useful for internal sign-off, sharing with stakeholders, or checking fine detail before going live.

Save as a Preset

If you want to reuse a certificate design across future activities, you can save it as a preset in your template library. Presets are accessible at any time and can be applied to new activities as a starting point, saving you from building the same design repeatedly.

To use a preset, open the Certificate Designer for any activity and load the preset from your library. You can then apply it as-is or make adjustments before saving.

Fixed Elements — Why They Cannot Be Removed

The following elements are present on every certificate and cannot be removed. These restrictions exist to protect the integrity, authenticity, and verifiability of CPD certificates issued through our platform.

Element	Reason it is required
Learner name	Identifies who the certificate belongs to — a certificate without a named recipient has no validity.
Date field	Confirms when the learner participated in the CPD activity. This is essential for CPD records and audits.
Course title	Identifies what CPD was completed. Without it, the certificate cannot be attributed to a specific learning activity.
Signature field	Provides authentication that the certificate was formally issued. It is a standard requirement for professional certification documents.
Accredited Activity Logo	Confirms that the activity has been accredited. Removing it would misrepresent the nature of the certificate.
Verification QR code	Allows anyone to verify the certificate's authenticity online. This is a core part of our verification process and ensures certificates cannot be easily forged.

Important These restrictions apply to all certificates issued through the platform, regardless of the design chosen. They cannot be overridden by any design setting or custom background image.

Design Tips and Best Practices

A few recommendations to help you get the best results from the Certificate Designer:

Match your brand closely

Use your exact brand hex colour codes rather than approximating with the colour picker. This ensures certificates look consistent with your other branded materials.

Use high-quality logo files

Upload logos at the highest resolution available. Low-resolution logos can appear blurry on printed or downloaded certificates. PNG files with transparent backgrounds give the cleanest result.

Design your background image with the certificate content in mind

If you're using a custom background, mock up where the certificate elements will sit before finalising your artwork. Leave clear, light-coloured areas for the learner name, title, date, and QR code.

Preview with realistic names

Test your design with both short and long delegate names. Some names may be significantly longer than others, so check the layout holds up across the range you're likely to see.

Save a preset early

Once you have a design you're happy with, save it as a preset before rolling it out. This gives you a safe baseline to return to if you want to tweak individual activities later.

Check the high-resolution download

The on-screen preview is a good working view, but always download the high-resolution version for final sign-off. Fine detail — particularly in logos and signatures — is much more visible at full resolution.